

Picking a wedge channel

Week 6, Lecture 1 — B2C to \$10k MRR

Growth Manual for Technical Founders · Autumn 2026

What we'll cover

- Why 19 traction channels exist but only 2-3 apply to you
- Channel-product fit: the concept that changes how you pick
- The one-channel obsession rule for weeks 6-9
- Three case studies: Levels, Lou, Dinh
- The Bullseye Framework in practice
- How to run the channel-fit worksheet today

The 19 channels

Weinberg and Mares: 19 traction channels

All the ways a startup has ever gotten customers, listed:

- Viral marketing, PR, unconventional PR
- Search engine marketing (SEM), social/display ads
- **SEO, content marketing, email marketing**
- Engineering-as-marketing (free tools)
- Targeting blogs, business development, sales
- Affiliate programs, existing platforms
- Trade shows, offline events, speaking, community

Source: *Traction* (Weinberg & Mares, 2015)

Most channels do not apply to a solo founder

The constraint: you have one person, 30 minutes of morning growth time.

- Paid channels (SEM, display) need a budget and a CAC model
- Trade shows, speaking need travel time and an existing brand
- BD and sales need a team to follow up
- Most PR strategies require an existing relationship

What remains: SEO, content, engineering-as-marketing, social, communities, Product Hunt.
That is still 6+ options — you still need to pick one.

Channel-product fit

The concept: channel and product must match

Weinberg and Mares argue channel-product fit matters as much as product-market fit.

A great product on the wrong channel grows slowly. A mediocre product on the right channel grows fast.

Two questions that reveal fit:

1. Where does your target user currently discover products like yours?
2. Can you produce the kind of content/asset that channel rewards?

A fit mismatch: language learning vs. image generation

Language learning (e.g., Duolingo):

- Users search "how to learn Spanish" actively
- SEO + content works because intent is explicit
- Community and habit loops extend retention

AI image generator:

- Discovery is visual and social, not search-driven
- Twitter and TikTok show results better than blog posts
- SEO on "how to generate art" captures researchers, not buyers

Same product category (consumer tool), different channel fit. (Hockenmaier & Rachitsky, First Round Review, 2019)

Lenny's Racecar: three growth lanes for consumer companies

Rachitsky and Hockenmaier (First Round Review, 2019) argue there are only three scalable lanes:

1. **Performance marketing** — paid ads; requires margin and scale before it pays off
2. **Virality** — word-of-mouth, referrals; requires a product people want to recommend
3. **Content / SEO** — organic search; requires patience (18-24 months typical) but compounds

Most solo founders have zero marketing budget in week 6. That leaves virality and content/SEO.

Case studies

Pieter Levels: SEO is a database problem

Nomad List (2014): started as a public spreadsheet of cities scored for remote work.

- Every city got a page: `/nomad-list/bangkok`, `/nomad-list/berlin`
- URL template: `/nomad-list/<city>` — instantly thousands of indexable pages
- Pages ranked for "best city for remote work" + city name
- Traffic converted via membership (\$99/year at launch)

Key insight: Levels did not write thousands of articles. He built a database and let the URL structure generate the pages. (Levels, IH podcast #043, 2018; levels.io/nomad-list-founder, 2024)

Marc Lou: Twitter + free tools

Marc Lou's February 2024 breakdown: \$45,250 in one month.

- Primary channel: Twitter/X (build-in-public posts)
- Free tools as SEO and viral assets: launch free mini-app → shares → backlinks → organic rank
- Product Hunt launches for each tool: spike + social proof

The conversion finding: YouTube visitors converted at 3x the rate of Twitter visitors — but YouTube cost 10x the effort. Lou stayed on Twitter because the output rate matched his solo workflow. (Marc Lou, YouTube revenue breakdown, 2024)

Tony Dinh: Product Hunt as a wedge

Tony Dinh (Xnapper, TypingMind) used Product Hunt as a repeatable launch channel.

- Launched multiple products; each launch generated backlinks and social proof
- Product Hunt traffic is not repeatable week-over-week (no compounding)
- He treated PH as a kickstart, then moved SEO and content to sustain growth

The lesson: even a channel that does not compound can be the right **wedge** to get early signal before committing to a compounding channel.

The Bullseye Framework

Bullseye: three rings

Weinberg and Mares' channel selection method (Traction, 2015):

Outer ring: brainstorm all channels. No filtering yet.

Middle ring: pick 3 channels with the highest channel-product fit signal. Run cheap experiments (2-4 weeks each).

Inner ring: one channel that is working — put all energy here.

The mistake most founders make: staying in the outer ring too long, or trying to run the inner ring with three channels at once.

The one-channel obsession rule

Weeks 6-9: every morning growth move goes to one channel only.

- No cross-posting "just to cover more ground"
- One channel means you can actually improve at it
- Data from one channel is actionable; data from five channels is noise

This is not permanent. The rule ends at week 10 when you have a compounding channel established or evidence that the channel does not fit.

Rachitsky (2022): "Most successful startups master a single engine before expanding."

Take-aways

1. 19 traction channels exist, but most require resources a solo founder does not have in week 6.
2. Channel-product fit is as important as product-market fit: the right product on the wrong channel grows slowly.
3. Three growth lanes for consumer companies: performance marketing, virality, content/SEO. Only the last two are available to a solo founder with no budget.
4. Case studies: Levels used a database to generate thousands of SEO pages; Lou stayed on Twitter because the output rate fit his workflow; Dinh used Product Hunt as a kickstart before building a compounding channel.
5. The Bullseye Framework: run 3-channel experiments in the middle ring, then lock the inner ring for weeks 6-9.

Channel-product fit matters as much as product-market fit.

Gabriel Weinberg and Justin Mares, *Traction* (2015)

What's next

- **Section today:** Channel-fit worksheet. Score 5 channels, pick 1, post publicly.
- **Lecture 2 (this week):** SEO + content engines. Programmatic SEO, topic clusters, Google Search Console.
- **Reading:** Week 6 reading at </c/b2c-10k-mrr-26au/readings/wk06> — required before section.
- **HW3 out:** Wedge channel sprint. Due week 7.

Discussion question

You have two products:

- **Product A:** a calendar tool for remote teams. Users search "remote team calendar" 8,000 times/month.
- **Product B:** an AI wallpaper generator. Users find it via screenshots shared on Twitter.

Which channel do you start with for each? What is the one piece of evidence that would make you change your answer?

References

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